



ANDROID ON A DUAL-SIM SMARTPHONE

A dual-SIM smartphone manufactured in China runs Android 2.2.1 Froyo. Geeks always find noteworthy products based on Linux!

Today, people are rarely surprised to see a dual-SIM phone [see Reference 1]. Phone manufacturers have been thinking about this feature for a long time—almost since the early 2000s. The pioneer was a Finnish company, Benefon, which came out with the Benefon Twin phone. The market didn't take to it, since mobiles were comparatively rare back then. Also, subscriptions from multiple GSM providers were regarded as a luxury.

However, the start of the price wars brought on by the increase in the number of operators in a particular market, led to a situation where customers enjoyed tariff plans with low rates for calls made to subscribers of the same cellular operator. A 'universal' service plan, with reasonable prices to all destinations, hadn't even been introduced in mid-2005. Naturally, people simultaneously using multiple GSM operators began to carry two or more cell phones. This consumer behaviour had its effect;

Philips, LG and Samsung gradually began to market dual-SIM devices. These were ordinary phones, not smartphones, lacking any bells and whistles in terms of the OS and mobile content support (not even a fully functional W3C browser, but Opera Mini or even a simple WAP browser).

Soon, the Chinese market became the most interesting, in terms of the rapid saturation in mobile connections. Due to reasons like the low average national industry wages (high profits came only from exporting, and from the coastal areas of China), the demand was for low-cost phones. Notably, most low-cost phones were based on a hardware platform of one company—MediaTek, head-quartered in Taiwan. MediaTek only manufactures a GSM integrated solution—a System-on-Chip (SoC) that is the main component, whilst many phone manufacturers in China just re-use it and market the end product (i.e., mobile phones) under their own brand names. This SoC includes Bluetooth, sometimes a Wi-Fi chip-set, and almost